

No Exit Wound

Widow's Bight, 1923 — alternate draft: the fight

Some part of Walter Corwin had always known the world came to him square — a box no wider than a man could hold between two hands, and past its edges not darkness, not fog, but absence, as though nothing had ever troubled itself to finish rendering beyond wherever he happened to be looking. He was thirty-one years old. He had never once wondered why. A man does not interrogate the shape of his own eye.

What he had wondered about, for as long as he'd carried a badge, was who got to decide what filled the square. He had learned early that this was not a question of honesty. Odell was not a dishonest man. The coroner was not a dishonest man. The town clerk who stamped forms in triplicate was, by any fair account, a conscientious clerk. And yet between the three of them, and a dozen others just as reasonable, entire lives went in and out of the official record the way weather goes in and out of a square window — present when it was present, and otherwise simply not a thing that had happened. Walter had spent ten years as a policeman coming to understand that the town did not need a villain to erase a person. It only needed enough small, defensible decisions, made by enough separate hands, none of which considered itself responsible for the sum.

He had decided, some years before this case ever found him, that he would be the hand that refused.

It rarely worked. He kept doing it anyway.

He came up the drive to the Ophion Club a little after four in the morning, and the gatehouse boy would not meet him at the edge of the frame, kept just at the rim of what Corwin could see, so that for the whole walk up the gravel the boy's face stayed a smear of gray at the corner of things, never quite arriving.

THEY'RE IN THE ROSE GARDEN, OFFICER. WHAT'S LEFT OF THEM.

The card the boy might as well have held up in front of his own trembling mouth, for all the sound that came with it. Walter had stopped noticing, years ago, that the words of other men arrived to him this way — clean, white, weightless, printed on the same silent register as

everything else in his life. He had a harder time not noticing how easily some words, once printed, got quietly filed and others didn't.

They lay in a half-circle behind the clipped hedges, six men in evening dress, each with a single black hole above the bridge of the nose, precise as a coin pressed into wax. No powder scorched their collars. No blood ran anywhere it should have pooled. Walter knelt beside Judge Absalom Wexford — forty years on the county bench, the same man who had sentenced Walter's own father to a month in the workhouse for public drunkenness — and found no exit wound at the back of the skull to answer the hole in front.

He knew three more on sight: Dr. Aldous Fenn, who had signed Constance Corwin's death certificate eleven months prior in a hand Walter had once resented for its beauty. District Attorney Miles Corliss, who had called him *a credit to the badge* at a dinner and forgotten his name within the hour. Otto Kessler, the butcher, whose good boning knife Walter found wiped too clean beneath a hedge root and bagged without comment. A fifth he placed by reputation alone — Josiah Pruitt, land and mills and deeds, the kind of fortune that spent half its life proving it owned the other half.

The sixth man carried nothing. No calling card, no monogram, no wallet, no maker's name on a watch stopped at seventeen past three. Walter wrote *UNKNOWN MALE, APPROX. 50–60, CLUB DRESS* and understood, even that first hour, that he was looking at the one blank in this case no amount of persistence would ever fill. He would ask the tailor. He would ask the steward. He would ask the undertaker whether any tooth or scar distinguished the man from the five beside him. Every answer would come back the same shape: *nobody admits knowing him, and everybody remembers he was there*. Some blanks in a case are not failures of the man investigating it. Some are simply how the case was built.

Thirty yards off, past a stand of birches, lay a woman and a boy. Their clothes were poor but not destitute — the coat too light for the season, the boy's shoes resoled twice — and whatever had been done to them had not been done with a single clean motion.

Walter stood over them a long moment. He had already decided, walking up from the six men, which way this hour was going to go if he let it go the way these hours usually went. A young coroner's assistant from Boston stood at his elbow with a folded sheet, waiting to be told which bodies mattered enough to photograph twice.

"Both scenes," Walter said. "Same crew. Same file."

The assistant blinked at him. "The captain generally wants the identified—"

"Both scenes," Walter said again, and wrote, in full, in a hand he made deliberately legible: *unidentified female — unidentified male, minor, presumed related — homicide, unresolved cause, full inquest requested.*

He did not write *transients*. He had written that word before, on other nights, for other bodies, and he had watched what happened to a file once that word went into it. He was not going to write it this time. He told himself this counted for something.

It counted for less than he expected. He would spend the next three weeks learning exactly how little a single refused word, from a single stubborn man, could do against a town that had a hundred other words ready to take its place.

The coroner did not answer with a card. He simply spread his hands over the row of sheeted tables, palms up, the international gesture of a learned man with nothing to teach.

WHY IS THERE NO EXIT WOUND, DOCTOR.

WHERE IS THE BULLET.

Nothing changed on the sheet.

Captain Odell arrived before noon and read Walter's preliminary notes with his thumb pressed hard against the line requesting a full inquest for all eight dead, as though pressure alone might make the sentence say something more convenient.

GAS-MAIN TRAGEDY, he suggested, to no one, without conviction, and Walter watched him reach for the same explanation Walter had already heard offered, in one form or another, for every convenient death this town had ever needed explained away.

"No burns," Walter said aloud, since a card felt too slow for what he wanted Odell to hear plainly. "No blast damage. No exit wounds. And there are eight bodies in that garden, not six."

"Six *members*," Odell said. "The other two are a filing matter."

"They're not a filing matter. They're a woman and a boy with a hole in each of them same as Judge Wexford."

Odell looked at him for a long moment, the particular look of a superior officer deciding how much patience a promising man was still owed. "You want a full inquest opened on two people nobody in this county can name."

"I can name them by supper," Walter said, "if you give me until supper."

He did not, in fact, have their names yet. He had only the certainty that he intended to get them, and enough experience of Odell to know that a man who announced intentions with total confidence bought himself more room than a man who asked permission. It worked, that once. Odell gave him three days rather than none, mostly, Walter suspected, because refusing outright would have required an explanation Odell did not want to have to give either of them.

Walter used the three days to make the refusal harder to walk back later. He filed his own report in triplicate — one copy to the precinct, one to the county registrar's office in Arkham proper, one kept in his own hand at Pickman Street, on the theory that a fact recorded in only one place had already halfway ceased to exist. He was not wrong about that theory. He would spend the rest of the case discovering just how thoroughly right he was.

Kessler's widow came to the precinct that same afternoon, demanding to know how her husband's shop money had bought him a chair among men who called him tradesman to his face. Odell steered her gently toward the door. Walter, on his way out, gave her his own name and Pickman Street address instead of the precinct's, and told her, plainly, that if anyone told her the case was closed before she'd had her answer, she should come find him there and not the captain.

It was the kind of thing a policeman was not, strictly, supposed to do. Walter did it anyway. He had come to think of it as the smallest tax he could pay against a much larger and much older debt the town had never once acknowledged owing.

He built the case the way he always built cases — a corkboard, twine, cards for what was known and cards for what was merely alleged, kept in separate columns because he had learned, the hard way, that the two categories curdled together if he let them. Six club members. Two names not yet found. A knife too clean. A watch with its maker's plate filed smooth.

He learned quickly that evidence in this town possessed different weight depending on which coat he wore while asking for it. In uniform, doors opened for him because a badge was owed courtesy. Out of uniform, in a plain wool coat and a pair of dead man's boots bought cheap at an estate sale, the same doors opened for an entirely different reason: because a man without a badge could be spoken to as though nothing spoken would ever officially exist. He began keeping both coats by the door and switching between them with something closer to strategy than habit. He did not enjoy how well the strategy worked. He used it anyway, because refusing a tool on principle, when the tool was the only thing that produced results, struck him as a luxury the case could not afford and he could not either.

The board rewarded exactly the kind of man he already was: patient, methodical, willing to sit with an uncomfortable fact until it agreed to sit next to another one. Higher up on the board, above the twine, he began keeping a second, smaller list that had nothing to do with names or dates. A list of doors that had been closed to him. A list of men who had told him plainly, in one wording or another, to let the matter rest. He did not let any of them rest. He crossed nothing off that list all case long, because crossing something off would have meant it had stopped costing him something to keep pushing against it, and it never once stopped.

The barman at the Ophion Club took three nights of Walter sitting quietly at the far end of the bar, drinking exactly one short pour and asking exactly one question each night, before he said anything worth writing down.

THEY STOPPED SPEAKING OF POWER, TOWARD THE END. THEY STARTED SPEAKING, TENDERLY, OF HER.

SHE'LL HAVE US HOME, Kessler had said, more than once. *SHE'S NO DIFFERENT FROM ANY MOTHER.*

Walter wrote it down and pinned it beside the rest, and felt the same thing he always felt when a hard-won fact finally agreed to sit where he'd put it: a clean, professional satisfaction that had nothing cursed about it. He had gotten good at this. He knew he had gotten good at this. Nothing about the getting-good ever announced itself as a cost. It only ever felt, hour after hour, like exactly what competence is supposed to feel like — useful, then more useful, then indispensable.

The following week the club revoked his drinking privileges outright — a policeman at the bar during an active investigation had become, in the steward's careful phrase, an embarrassment the membership no longer wished to extend courtesy to — and Odell, informed of the complaint, sided with the club without asking Walter a single question about it first.

Walter did not accept this quietly. He went to Odell's office and stood in the doorway until the captain looked up.

"You're going to let five wealthy men decide how I run a murder case."

"I'm going to let five wealthy men complain to the mayor's office, same as they always have, and I am going to have to answer for it, same as I always do," Odell said. "You want to keep working

this case, Corwin, you keep it quiet enough that I don't have to choose between you and my own position. That's not a threat. That's arithmetic."

Walter understood, standing there, that Odell was not lying to him and was not, by his own lights, even being unreasonable. That was the thing he could never get any purchase on. He had spent his whole career looking for a man he could out-argue, a decision he could appeal past, a single bad actor whose bad faith might be exposed and corrected. He kept finding, instead, an arithmetic — reasonable men making reasonable calculations that added up, every time, to the same absence.

He kept working the case anyway. He simply stopped asking anyone's permission first.

A boardinghouse keeper on Pickman Street, a Mrs. Almy, had fed the dead woman a bowl of stew more than once and had given Walter nothing across two visits in uniform. On the third visit, in the plain coat, she opened the door, looked at him a long moment, and let him in.

She told him the woman's name — Naomi Freeman — and gave him, across the better part of an hour, something closer to a history than a case note: an older son, grown and gone off on his own, named Ekon; a lay, a whaler's unpaid wage, owed a hundred years back to an ancestor who'd sailed and died aboard a ship called the *Ophion*; documents Naomi had carried and half-hidden, frightened of being asked about them by the wrong people.

Walter wrote the name Ekon Freeman at the bottom of a page and, unlike other nights when he might have let a fact like that sit quietly in a column marked *civil, not criminal*, he went the next morning directly to the county registrar's office and tried to open a formal inquiry into the wage claim itself — not because he expected the county to honor a hundred-year-old debt, but because he wanted the claim's existence written down somewhere official, in a hand that was not only his own, before anyone with a reason to make it disappear got the chance.

The clerk behind the counter heard him out with real, if limited, sympathy.

"You'd need a living claimant," the clerk said. "A next of kin with standing. You said yourself the mother's dead."

"There's a son."

"Where is he?"

Walter did not know. He wrote *EKON FREEMAN — WHEREABOUTS UNKNOWN* on the same line where the claim itself sat, and the clerk, not unkindly, told him that a claim with no living claimant in the room to press it was, procedurally, no claim at all — not a lie exactly, not even

really a refusal, just the ordinary shape of a door that had never been built to open for a man who wasn't standing in front of it in person.

Walter left the claim on file anyway, under his own name as the reporting officer, on the theory that a document sitting inert in a drawer somewhere was still, technically, harder to erase than a document that had never been written at all. He would never learn whether that theory held. He would not live long enough to check.

When he thanked Mrs. Almy and turned to leave her kitchen that same week, she caught his sleeve.

YOU WEAR THAT LIKE IT BELONGS TO SOMEBODY ELSE, OFFICER.

He looked down at the coat and could not, in that moment, have said with any confidence which garment she meant.

He tried the *Arkham Gazette* next, on the theory that a fact printed in a hundred copies was harder to erase than a fact filed in one drawer.

The reporter who took his statement was young and plainly interested — until an editor, two desks over, glanced at the names Walter had written down and quietly suggested the young man might want a second source before running anything that named five of the county's most generous advertisers as members of a private society with a body count. The story that eventually ran gave the six dead men their names, their professions, a paragraph each on their civic contributions, and a closing line about an ongoing police investigation into "an apparent accident." It did not mention the birches. It did not mention two more names Walter had personally supplied.

He went back to the paper's offices once, in the plain coat, and asked the editor directly why two people were missing from a story about eight deaths.

"Because I've got a paper to put out next week too," the editor told him, not unkindly, and Walter understood that this, too, was arithmetic rather than malice — a man protecting a business that employed eleven people, weighed against two people that business had never once had any obligation toward.

He did not stop asking. He simply stopped expecting the asking to change the arithmetic.

He went to Father Behan behind the rectory, not inside it, and got the priest to admit, eventually, that the club's own founding money traced to an insurance settlement paid out after a fleet's loss a hundred years back — a settlement three families had turned, over the generations, into land and mills and a private club they'd named, with a flourish Walter came to understand was pure vanity rather than prophecy, after the very ship that had made them rich by sinking.

"They came to believe the ship had been chosen," Behan told him.

"Was it?"

IT WASN'T, the priest wrote, with something closer to disgust than reverence than Walter had expected from a churchman. *MEN INHERIT MONEY AND THEN INVENT A REASON THEY DESERVED IT.*

Walter asked whether the church would say as much publicly — from the pulpit, in a letter, anywhere at all that might put pressure where pressure could not simply be absorbed by an editor's discretion or a clerk's procedure. Behan looked at him for a long moment with something that might have been respect and might have been pity, and said nothing further that Walter could write down. Walter understood the silence for what it was: one more reasonable man, protecting one more reasonable institution, adding one more small brick to a wall that no single brick could be blamed for.

The tunnel, when he finally found it — behind a boarded pantry door the barman told him about out of guilt rather than loyalty, at the end of a service corridor that ran longer than the building above it had any right to — did not, at first, feel to Walter like the end of an investigation. It felt like the last unexamined door in a town that had spent three weeks quietly closing every other one in his face.

He went down in the plain coat and the dead man's boots, because some low, unlit part of him had decided the badge had no jurisdiction over ground that didn't officially exist. The flask went first, torn loose by a spur of rock, gone into the dark with two soft strikes and then nothing. He did not chase it. He had, by then, stopped expecting anything down here to hold still and wait for him the way the town above had refused to.

The passage gave back more than it took, if a man kept paying attention. Not brighter. Clearer — a reflective edge on wet stone he'd have missed a month before, a silhouette resolving where an earlier version of himself would have seen only dark. He had not asked for the improvement. He had simply kept working the same muscle he'd worked all case long, on witnesses and clerks and reluctant editors, and the muscle, it turned out, did not know or care that the ground beneath it had changed.

The first bodies were sailors, drowned and bloated and entirely without malice in the shape of their ruin. Farther on, the others — collar and cufflink on flesh that had gone on changing long after drowning should have ended the matter — and one, nearer the stair than he'd have liked, whose eyes opened when his lantern found its face, and whose first sound was a thin, wet cough that landed on him with a shock no amount of theory could have prepared him for.

He put six rounds into it and it staggered and did not fall, and he understood, in the same flat part of his mind that had spent three weeks learning exactly how much a reasonable, well-aimed effort could and could not accomplish against a town's arithmetic, that the gun had never been going to kill it either. Only buy him time. He drove Kessler's knife in low, not to kill, and the blow held it down a few seconds longer than the same blow would have bought him a month earlier — not because his aim had improved, it hadn't, but because whatever had strengthened in his arms these past weeks over crates and courthouse ledgers and church windowsills purchased him precisely that: a little more time, never a clean end. He tore free and ran, put his boot through the skull of a drowned sailor reaching for his ankle and felt it give in a way the other thing had never once come close to, and did not stop running until the pantry's ordinary dust was under his ordinary boots again.

He sat there a long while, hands shaking, no flask, no rounds left in the cylinder, and understood that he had just spent his last real advantage in a fight that had never, from the very first card the gatehouse boy held up, been arranged to let him win it. He went home anyway. He kept working anyway. He had built the habit too deep by then to know how to stop.

The board filled. Not the courtroom kind of full — that file stayed damaged to the last, the sixth man unnamed, the wage claim inert in a drawer with no living claimant to press it, the newspaper's silence intact, Odell's patience by then entirely spent. But the other kind, the kind that required only enough of the right facts arranged correctly: six men, a ship, an insurance settlement dressed generations later as a mother's mercy, a tunnel with no business existing, a cough that answered to nothing living.

THEY DID NOT SUMMON A MOTHER. THEY SUMMONED SOMETHING AND CALLED IT ONE.

He did not remember writing those lines. He checked them against everything else he'd gathered and found them true regardless of who or what had put them in his own hand. The board was whole enough. The frame widened.

Color came in unevenly — a red thread stretched taut between two cards, the rose garden itself fully present in memory and staying that way — and sound came in beneath it, his mother's cough, and then her voice, occupying the room the way temperature occupies a room, everywhere at once and nowhere in particular. The shape that wore it never once resolved into anything so simple as a face. It had found the heaviest thing sitting closest to the surface of him and worn it the way water wears whatever cup is offered, not out of malice, not out of love, only out of proximity. Six frightened men had knelt in a rose garden and begged a mother's mercy from something that had never once been capable of mercy or its opposite. Walter understood, in the same instant, that he had spent three weeks fighting a town that could not have granted him mercy either, not out of cruelty, only out of the same complete indifference dressed in more paperwork.

His mind, in its last clear seconds, reached for the oldest refuge it owned — a square yellow-curtained room, his mother coughing patient in her bed, an unopened exemption notice folded on the dresser, a version of himself who had never once left that room and therefore never once earned any of what came after. It was not true. It had never been true. He had spent three weeks refusing to let a town erase two names by the same easy arithmetic it had erased a hundred others, and the refusal had been real even though nothing about the outcome had changed for having made it.

That, in the end, was the whole of what he managed to leave behind: not a case solved, not a claim honored, not a story printed, not a captain persuaded — only a file, kept in triplicate against exactly this outcome, that recorded eight names where the town's own version would record six. He had fought for that single stubborn number with everything a beat cop's authority actually contained, and had lost every larger fight along the way, and the number survived regardless, in a drawer in Arkham and in his own hand on Pickman Street, because he had made it survive rather than simply hoping it might.

Whether that counted as a victory was not a question the case had ever been built to answer for him.

He reached for the file. Whether his hand touched it, no report would ever say. No body was recovered. Captain Odell's eventual replacement file would record that Officer Walter Corwin had disappeared under personal strain following an unresolved accident at the Ophion Club, and would find, in its six tidy paragraphs, room for six names and none at all for two more — the same erasure Walter had spent three weeks fighting, arriving anyway, on schedule, the moment there was no longer a stubborn man left standing in its way.

The frame no longer had edges left to widen. It simply stopped needing him to fill it, and went on without him — and somewhere outside the town's own accounting, in a drawer that had not yet been found, a number he had insisted on kept standing at eight.

END OF CHAPTER ONE — ALTERNATE DRAFT